Concerns about the secrecy of the planned operation were expressed not only by Soviet commanders such as Dementiev but also by the Cubans. Raúl Castro, who came to Moscow in early July to negotiate an agreement on the deployment of the missiles, was just as uneasy about the prospect. Fidel Castro wanted an official and public agreement with the Soviets. "What precautions have you taken in case the operation is discovered by the United States before it is made public?" Raúl asked Khrushchev. "Don't worry, I'll grab Kennedy by the balls and make him negotiate," responded the Soviet leader. It seems to have escaped him that grabbing someone by the balls if he already had a hedgehog down his pants was a highly dangerous undertaking.[2]

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THE COMMANDER OF THE STRATEGIC MISSILE FORCES, MARSHAL Biriuzov, approved the plans for what was officially called "Anadyr Maneuvers" on June 13, 1962, three days after Khrushchev and the Presidium gave their official approval for the operation. The Soviet rocket men learned of their secret assignment a few days later, when Biriuzov's first deputy, Colonel General Vladimir Tolubko, arrived at the headquarters of the 43rd Missile Division of the 43rd Missile Army in the Ukrainian city of Romny, an old Cossack town more than two hundred kilometers east of the republic's capital, Kyiv. A former commander of a tank army in Dresden, East Germany, Tolubko had been transferred to the newly formed Strategic Missile Forces in 1960 and was now responsible for the transportation of the missile troops to Cuba. He called in the divisional commanding officers for a meeting.[3]

"The meeting took place under conditions of extraordinary secrecy: serious guard posts were placed, doors closed, and blinds drawn—counterintelligence officers had been at work," remembered First Lieutenant and Young Communist League organizer Igor Kurennoi. "In a half-whisper Colonel General Tolubko announced: 'Comrade officers, the party and government are showing great confidence in you. Your division will be obliged to undertake a highly responsible mission. It will be beyond